Northstar Services

Product Information, Service Requests and Troubleshooting Procedure

Product Questions, Feature Availability, Technical Triage, Outages and Service Requests

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1. Purpose

This procedure gives customer-service employees a repeatable method for answering product questions and handling service requests without making unsupported technical claims. It applies to software services, customer portals, subscriptions, integrations, and supported customer devices.

The representative's role is to identify the customer's objective, collect the minimum information needed, provide approved guidance, and route issues that require specialist intervention. Representatives should not attempt unrestricted technical experimentation on a customer's production environment.

2. Product Inquiry Triage

Classify the contact before troubleshooting. Common categories are feature question, configuration question, compatibility question, account-access question, service request, defect report, performance issue, and suspected outage.

Capture the product or plan name, relevant version, environment, affected feature, expected behavior, observed behavior, error message, approximate start time, and scope of impact. If the customer has already performed troubleshooting, record the steps and results so the next employee does not repeat them unnecessarily.

A feature request should not be classified as a defect simply because the customer expected the feature to exist.

3. Approved Product Answers

Use the current product knowledge base, release notes approved for customer communication, and product-specific procedures. When multiple sources conflict, use the controlled source designated as authoritative and report the conflict to Knowledge Management.

Do not promise that a planned feature will be released on a particular date unless the date is explicitly approved for external communication. Do not disclose internal project names, unreleased security details, or confidential roadmap information.

When a customer asks "Can your product do X?", answer the exact capability and relevant limitations. If X can be achieved only through a workaround, clearly label the workaround rather than implying native support.

4. Basic Troubleshooting

Troubleshooting must follow approved procedures in sequence. Start with low-risk checks such as confirming service status, account state, configuration, supported version, connectivity, and reproducibility.

Before recommending a potentially disruptive action, explain the expected effect and any data or access risk. Do not instruct customers to delete production data, disable security controls permanently, bypass authentication, install unapproved software, or modify system files unless a controlled procedure explicitly authorizes it.

If troubleshooting resolves the issue, document the confirmed cause when known and the successful corrective step. If it does not resolve the issue, preserve the evidence collected and escalate rather than repeating the same steps indefinitely.

5. Defect Reports

A defect report should describe expected behavior, actual behavior, reproduction steps, affected environment, frequency, error messages, approximate first occurrence, business impact, and supporting evidence that may safely be attached.

Use neutral language. A report should state "Customer receives HTTP 500 when submitting the form with three attachments" rather than "the application is completely broken."

Severity should reflect customer impact and scope. A defect affecting one low-impact workflow may remain normal priority, while a defect preventing all customers from completing a critical transaction may require incident escalation.

6. Service Requests

Service requests are actions requested by a customer that are supported by a defined operational workflow, such as configuration changes, account setup assistance, entitlement checks, or approved administrative actions.

Verify authorization before making changes. Confirm the requested change, effective date, affected service, and any customer-visible consequences. Where two-person approval or specialist approval is required, do not bypass the control because the customer is waiting.

After completion, verify the resulting state in the system and communicate the outcome. A request is not complete merely because an internal ticket was created.

7. Outage and Incident Handling

When multiple customers report the same failure or the service-status system indicates an incident, representatives should stop treating each contact as an unrelated defect. Follow the incident communication procedure and link cases to the known incident where available.

Representatives should communicate only approved incident information: affected service, known impact, current status, available workaround, and next update time if published. Do not speculate about root cause or recovery time.

If no incident is declared but evidence suggests a widespread problem, notify the designated service-operations channel with examples, timestamps, regions, and affected functionality. The representative should continue to support individual customers using the approved incident procedure.

8. Escalation to Technical Teams

Escalate when the approved troubleshooting path is exhausted, the issue requires privileged access, a defect is suspected, the customer is experiencing material business impact, or the issue involves a security-sensitive configuration.

A technical escalation must contain enough information to act without restarting discovery. Include customer impact, environment, reproduction steps, timestamps, error messages, correlation or reference IDs where permitted, troubleshooting already completed, and the specific question for the technical team.

Do not include unnecessary personal data in technical tickets.

9. Follow-Up and Closure

For unresolved product issues, communicate a realistic next update rather than an unsupported resolution date. If the technical team provides an update, translate it into customer-facing language without changing its meaning.

Close the service request only after the requested action is completed or the approved closure condition is met. Defect reports may remain open while the product team investigates; customer-service cases may be closed with a link or reference to the tracked issue if the workflow allows it.

If the customer contacts support again about the same issue, link the new interaction to the existing technical record.

Appendix A — Quick Decision Reference

Feature availability unclear	Consult the authoritative product source; do not rely on memory.
Troubleshooting requires risky action	Stop and use the controlled procedure or specialist route.
Same error appears for many customers	Check incident status and notify service operations.
Technical escalation	Include environment, reproduction steps, timestamps, errors, impact, and completed troubleshooting.
Feature request	Classify as a request unless the documented product behavior indicates a defect.
Customer reports resolved issue	Document the successful step and verify the final state where possible.